

Poppies in July



SUMMARY

The speaker gazes at a field of poppies and speaks to them, calling them hell flames and asking them if they really don't do any harm.

Though the flowers flicker like fire, the speaker can't touch them; when she puts her hand among the flowers, they don't burn her.

Watching them tires the speaker out. Their crinkly red petals make her think of lips.

They make her think of bloody lips—or perhaps bloodstained skirts!

She knows that inside the poppies lie chemicals that she can't reach: numbing opiates, nauseating pills.

If only, she thinks, she could bleed like the poppies seem to, or sleep like the poppy's opiates could help her to; if only she could fully feel or express the pain that the poppies reflect at her.

She wishes that the poppies' opiates could reach her, calming her and slowing her down—even though those drugs would also take away all the world's colors.

the flames” and to be dismayed when “nothing burns.” She’s left “exhaust[ed]” by the experience: physical pain seems to strike her as a welcome distraction. She longs to feel that her “mouth can marry a hurt like that”—that, through physical pain, she could make her emotional pain as clear, visible, and *speakeable* as the redness of a “mouth just bloodied.” But the poppies can't help her there.

Since the speaker can't find relief from her pain in hurting herself, she instead turns longingly to thoughts of numbness. Knowing that poppies produce “opiates” (drugs that kill pain, induce sleep, and inspire dreams), she dreams of escape through the plant’s “dulling and stilling” powers. Living a “colorless,” deadened life, in other words, strikes her as preferable to yet more suffering.

But both of the speaker’s desires—for distracting physical hurt or deadening numbness—feel out of her reach. She pleads with the poppies: “Where are your opiates, your nauseous capsules?” No answer comes; she can't numb her pain out any more than she can change its nature. Her desire to “bleed, or sleep” in the end leaves her stranded with one terrible fact: there's no easy escape from emotional pain, at least not without terrible costs.



THEMES



PAIN AND ESCAPE

The speaker of “Poppies in July” is in terrible emotional pain. Gazing at a field of blossoming poppies at the height of summer—a sight that might strike a different person as reassuring or consoling—she can only see her own suffering reflected back at her. She longs for relief, but when even the beauty of the natural world only speaks of pain, solace is hard to find. Through images of poppies’ blood-red petals and soothing “opiates,” the speaker reveals that she can think of only two routes out of her pain: transforming it from emotional to physical suffering, or numbing herself out altogether. But some pains, the poem suggests, just can't be evaded.

Staring at the poppies, the speaker can see in them only images of violence and pain. Their brilliant, “flickering” petals strike her as “hell flames” and the “skin of [...] a mouth just bloodied,” images that suggest the outside world is reflecting her own agony back at her. Clearly, she's in the midst of overwhelming emotional pain.

Part of the speaker seems to want to transfer her pain from her soul to her body. When she imagines the poppies as “hell flames,” for instance, her impulse is to “put [her] hand among

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-15



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-4

*Little poppies, little ...
... flames. Nothing burns.*

“Poppies in July” begins with a strange [apostrophe](#): the speaker has a chat with a field of summer poppies. Her tone is unsettling. While she affectionately calls the flowers “little poppies,” a moment later she calls them “little hell flames,” and asks them, with seeming mingled dread and eagerness, “Do you do no harm?” That uncanny mixture of sweetness and horror will inform this whole poem.

As it turns out, the speaker might prefer it if these dainty little flowers *could* do some harm. As they “flicker” like hellfire, she doesn't draw back, but “put[s her] hands among the flames,” only to discover that “nothing burns.” She *sees* terrible things in these poppies, then; she sees the fires of hell itself. But the horror is all inside her.

It takes a certain state of mind to see hell in a field of poppies. This speaker is clearly in a frightening place, going through

agonizing mental and emotional pain. The loaded [metaphor](#) of “hell flames” underscores that idea: these aren’t just any old fires, but fires of torment, judgment, and damnation. The speaker’s vague hope that the poppies might actually burn her hints that physical pain seems preferable to the kind of mental anguish that transforms a field of summer flowers into hell itself.

Compounding her pain is the fact that she can’t even seem to “touch” the poppies, let alone be burned by them. Part of her suffering, then, comes from a sense of being cut off from ordinary sensation. Her pain isolates her.

[Paradoxically](#), though, these images of inaccessibility also conjure up a vivid, tangible real-life scene. A blood-red, blazing field of poppies, their petals so delicate that they “flicker.” There’s beauty here, for sure—but the speaker is in no state of mind to perceive it or be comforted by it.

In this poem, Plath will explore anguish across 15 lines of [free verse](#). Most of the poem is divided into neat two-line stanzas, each framing one or two blood-red, nightmarish images.

LINES 5-8

*And it exhausts ...
... Little bloody skirts!*

Discovering that the flame-like poppies can’t burn her—and that she can’t even seem to touch them, for that matter—the speaker is left “exhaust[ed].” The poppies’ constant “flickering” seems full of an energy she just doesn’t have.

They remind her, too, of uncomfortable things. “Wrinkly and clear red,” the petals strike her as “like the skin of a mouth.” That [simile](#) at first seems rather sensual. In choosing the words “the skin of a mouth” rather than, say, “lips,” the speaker conjures the wet inner lip, not just the outer surface you might adorn with poppy-red lipstick. And the comparison between mouth and poppies’ delicate “wrinkly” petals suggests sensation as much as sight.

But this sensual [imagery](#) tips over into violence. Listen to the [anadiplosis](#) that links the third stanza to the fourth:

[...] the skin of a mouth.

A mouth just bloodied.

Through this [repetition](#), the very same mouth that suggested kisses a moment ago is suddenly “bloodied,” and freshly, as if just smacked. The reader might feel smacked here, too! Against the longer, more thoughtful line 4, the short, sharp, disturbing line 5 lands like a blow.

There’s both sexuality and violence here, then. That association becomes even clearer when the speaker goes on to exclaim, “Little bloody skirts!” Those [metaphorical](#) bloody skirts call up feminine pain, in particular: menstruation, assault, or sexual

violence.

The cloud of imagery and associations here suggests that this speaker is suffering a kind of pain that has a lot to do with being a woman. What *kind* of female pain, exactly, the poem doesn’t specify. But that vagueness is all part of the poem’s power. It’s as if the reader is looking in on the speaker’s personal nightmare, a welter of horror-red images as poppies turn to lips and skirts and blood.

LINES 9-12

*There are fumes ...
... hurt like that!*

So far, the speaker has focused on poppies’ bloody, fleshy qualities. Now, she turns to poppies’ other famous property: the fact that their seed pods produce “opiates.” These drugs, like opium, laudanum, and heroin, are powerful painkillers and soporifics (that is, they induce sleep). For the suffering speaker, a little drugged unconsciousness might sound pretty good. But she “cannot touch” the poppies’ sleepy drugs any more than she could “touch” the fire she saw in their petals back in line 3 (“You flicker. I cannot touch you”). Again, she makes a desperate [apostrophe](#) to the poppies, imploring them to reveal where their “opiates” might lie.

But the poppies, of course, don’t answer. And even as the speaker begs them for relief, she seems to know that she’s asking for a poisoned pill. In picturing a poppy-drugged sleep, she imagines “fumes” and “nauseous capsules”: sickly gaseous smells, queasy pills. The numbness the poppies [symbolically](#) represent here is sickening in its own way, then. Checking out of pain (perhaps through intense medication) comes at a price.

Still, the speaker wishes desperately either to “sleep” (as those opiates might help her to) or to “bleed.” In other words, she wants either to *escape* her emotional pain or *transform* it by expressing it as physical pain, something outside her (as when she hoped the poppies might burn her hand like “hell flames”).

Her awareness that she “cannot touch” either of these options compounds her agony, then. She’s trapped in emotional and mental pain that both spills out into the world around her and cuts her off from that world.

Desperate [anaphora](#) carries her up to an agonized [metaphor](#):

*If I could bleed, or sleep!—
If my mouth could marry a hurt like that!*

That repeated “if” captures the speaker’s tormented longing for a release she just can’t get. In her pain, she returns to the image of the mouth, this time imagining its bloodied “hurt” as something it could “marry.” The metaphor suggests that she wants to *merge* with what she sees in the poppies, to form a union with what she currently “cannot touch.” She wants, in other words, to fully *embody* and *express* what the poppies show

to her: fiery, hellish, bloody pain.

LINES 13-15

*Or your liquors ...
... But colorless. Colorless.*

If the speaker can't "marry" the "hurt" she sees in the poppies, she'd be willing to take numbness, instead. She dreams that the poppies' potent "liquors" might "seep to [her]," oozing out "in this glass capsule." That ambiguous image might equally suggest the poppies' juices enclosed in a fragile glass pill that the speaker can swallow (like the "nauseous capsules" of line 10), or the speaker *herself* trapped in a "glass capsule" that the poppies' opiates can ooze through. (The image of deep depression as enclosure in glass will be familiar to readers of Plath's novel [The Bell Jar](#).)

If those drugs could make it to her, the speaker imagines, they'd "dull[]" and "still[]" her agony. They'd numb her out, in other words. But numbness comes at a price. The poppies' imagined sedative "liquors," in contrast with the brilliant bloody flowers that produced them, are "colorless." The speaker returns to that word twice in the poem's final line, the only one-line stanza in the whole poem:

But colorless. Colorless.

That [epizeuxis](#) slows the poem to a halt, deadening and cutting off the poem just as the drugs might deaden the speaker's pain. To choose numbness over agony, these closing words suggest, is also to choose nothing over something, colorlessness over color. But when red petals look like hellfire, nothingness might seem like a tempting devil's bargain.

dangers.

Where this symbol appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-15



POETIC DEVICES

IMAGERY

"Poppies in July" is built on the back of intense [imagery](#). The poem is awash with one color: red. Sometimes blazing like "hell flames," sometimes oozing like "a mouth just bloodied," the color of poppies here embodies the speaker's horror and pain.

As the speaker gazes at a field of poppies, she finds their red "flickering" overwhelming and even "exhaust[ing]." Their brilliant color and perpetual motion mirror her own emotional suffering, which similarly "flicker[s]" in her like a constant fire and drips from her like blood from a wound.

Holding that bright red pain inside her starts to feel like too much to the speaker. She begins to wish that the poppies were real fires in which she could burn herself, thus making her suffering visible to others (and perhaps distracting her, too). But to her dismay, "nothing burns" when she puts her hand among the poppies.

But that sense of numbness, an inability to translate emotional pain into physical pain, also gives her an idea. Poppies are the source of many different opiates, drugs that can put you to sleep or relieve your pain. The speaker thus dreams that, if she can't express her pain physically, she might instead numb it out, drawing on the poppies' "dulling and stilling" power. Overwhelmed, she longs for a "colorless" inertia, an image that suggests she feels willing to sacrifice *all* experience—pleasure as well as pain—if she can only get a little relief from her suffering.

Where Imagery appears in the poem:

- **Lines 3-4:** "You flicker. I cannot touch you. / I put my hands among the flames. Nothing burns."
- **Line 6:** "Flickering like that, wrinkly and clear red, like the skin of a mouth."
- **Line 10:** "your nauseous capsules"
- **Line 14:** "Dulling and stilling"
- **Line 15:** "But colorless. Colorless."

METAPHOR

The speaker's hallucinatory [metaphors](#) capture the mood of a nightmare come to life.

In line 1, for instance, a field of poppies—perfectly innocent little flowers—strikes the speaker as an expanse of "hell flames." That image immediately introduces ideas of pain and judgment;



SYMBOLS



THE POPPIES

The poppies [symbolize](#) the speaker's feelings: pain, and a longing to escape from pain. They also hint that there's something specially *feminine* about the kind of suffering she's enduring.

The scarlet flowers put the speaker in mind of a number of feminine images: skirts, lipstick-red mouths. But all of those images also suggest injury: "little bloody skirts," "a mouth just bloodied." Symbolically, this suggests that the speaker feels hurt in a way that might be related to womanhood—perhaps sexual violence or betrayal.

The "opiates" that the speaker knows those poppies contain, meanwhile, spur her longing for relief from her pain. A dull, "colorless" sleep is the only respite she can imagine from her suffering. Because poppies produce pain-killing, soporific drugs, they're an elegant symbol of that desire—and of its

the speaker is clearly suffering the torments of the damned. But she also seems almost disappointed when she “put[s] her hand among the flames” and finds that they can’t burn her. These metaphors suggest that she longs for her emotional suffering to become physical. Outward pain might be easier to bear than the inner kind—or might, at least, distract her.

That idea becomes even more intense when she wishes that her “mouth might marry a hurt like that”: in other words, if she could somehow *unite* with her pain, perhaps by expressing it in lasting words (as she does in this very poem). To “marry a hurt” might also again suggest making pain public and visible, showing the world how deeply she’s been wounded (just as a marriage makes a public statement of a relationship). Her earlier visions of the poppies as “a mouth just bloodied” chimes with this image: the kind of pain she’s feeling could only be accurately embodied by wounded, bleeding lips.

Other metaphors hint at the *kind* of pain she might be suffering. When she pictures the poppies as “little bloody skirts,” the image suggests women’s agonies in particular. A bloody skirt might evoke anything from menstruation to sexual assault to murder. Perhaps some of this speaker’s trouble, then, has to do with womanhood. Readers who know a little bit about this poem’s context will be aware that Plath had recently discovered her husband Ted Hughes’s infidelities when she wrote “Poppies in July”; her images of distinctly feminine wounds might get at the agony of romantic betrayal.

Where Metaphor appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** “Little poppies, little hell flames,”
- **Line 7:** “A mouth just bloodied.”
- **Line 8:** “Little bloody skirts!”
- **Line 12:** “If my mouth could marry a hurt like that!”

SIMILE

The poem uses a single ghastly [simile](#) to capture the speaker’s pain and violation. Speaking to the poppies, the speaker declares that:

[...] it exhausts me to watch you
Flickering like that, wrinkly and clear red, like the skin
of a mouth.

A mouth just bloodied.

At first, the image of a poppy’s bright, crinkled petals as the “skin of a mouth” feels precise, lively, and sensual, conjuring up visions of bright red lipstick. By saying the “skin of a mouth” rather than “lips,” the speaker also invites readers to imagine sensation: making lips a little more alien and comparing them to poppy petals, she evokes the soft, crinkled *touch* of lips.

That hint of sexuality collapses into violence when the speaker

specifies that the skin of the mouth she’s imagining is “just bloodied.” The poppy’s color doesn’t suggest lipstick, then, but the fresh blood of recent violence. These are lips that have been hit or bitten.

This transition from the sensuous to the violent fits into the poem’s bigger picture, in which the speaker’s pain seems to have something to do with injured womanhood and sexuality. Speaking through oblique images, the speaker doesn’t even seem ready to look directly at how she’s been hurt.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Line 6:** “Flickering like that, wrinkly and clear red, like the skin of a mouth.”

REPETITION

[Repetitions](#) help to express the speaker’s emotional intensity.

In line 1, for instance, [anaphora](#) captures her almost hypnotized gaze as she stares at a field of “**little poppies, little hell flames.**” The repeated “little” there sets up an eerie surprise. “Little poppies” could be the first words of a peaceful Romantic poem about the restorative beauty of nature; the shocking transition to “little hell flames” makes it clear this will be a very different kind of poem. It’s as if the speaker is in a nightmare, watching innocent little poppies transforming into the very fires of hell before her eyes.

Other repetitions help the reader to share the speaker’s fascinated, horrified perspective. The [anadiplosis](#) of “the skin of a mouth. / A mouth just bloodied,” for instance, again carries readers from a (relatively) innocent image into a violent one.

No wonder that she longs to escape from these tormenting visions into oblivion. “If I could bleed, or sleep! — / If my mouth could marry a hurt like that!”, she cries, her yearning anaphora on “if” capturing her hopeless desire for some kind of relief. In the end, the most that she can hope for is a “dulling” numbness, something “colorless. Colorless.” The grim [epizeuxis](#) of those closing words slows the poem down as sedation slows a heartbeat.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 1:** “Little,” “little”
- **Line 3:** “I”
- **Line 4:** “I”
- **Lines 6-7:** “a mouth. / A mouth”
- **Line 7:** “bloodied”
- **Line 8:** “Little,” “bloody”
- **Line 10:** “your,” “your,” “capsules”
- **Line 11:** “If”
- **Line 12:** “If”
- **Line 13:** “capsule”
- **Line 15:** “colorless,” “Colorless”

APOSTROPHE

The speaker's [apostrophes](#) to the poppies give this poem an eerie, fairy-tale tone.

At first, the speaker talks to the poppies in what almost seem like terms of endearment, calling them "little poppies" as you might call a cute dog "little puppy." But that tone quickly becomes unsettling: the poppies turn into "little hell flames" and "little bloody skirts," images that marry a cutesy diminutive to a dangerous image. The speaker is aware, then, that she's seeing horrors in innocent flowers; she can feel how her own pain is seeping out into the world around her, and perhaps she's as unnerved by that bleed as her reader is.

Likewise unnerving is the fact that these poppies cannot and will not respond to her. Though she begs them to tell her where their "opiates" lurk, they give no reply. They can't even give her the dark consolation she hopes for: total "colorless" oblivion.

In speaking to the poppies, then, the speaker underscores her own suffering, fear, and isolation. The flowers she reaches out to can't help her; she's totally alone with her pain, talking to beings that can't respond. The poppies only reflect her troubles back at her.

Where Apostrophe appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "Little poppies, little hell flames, / Do you do no harm?"
- **Line 3:** "You flicker. I cannot touch you."
- **Line 5:** "And it exhausts me to watch you"
- **Line 8:** "Little bloody skirts!"
- **Line 10:** "Where are your opiates, your nauseous capsules?"
- **Line 13:** "Or your liquors seep to me, in this glass capsule,"

doesn't use a regular [meter](#) or a [rhyme scheme](#). Instead, Plath shapes the poem's lines as she pleases, using irregular rhythms to frame intense images.

The 15 lines of "Poppies in July" are grouped into seven two-line stanzas and one concluding one-liner. Each of these short, sharp stanzas frames a moment of unsettling [imagery](#) as the speaker considers a field of poppies, first seeing them as a reflection of her own pain ("little bloody skirts," "a mouth just bloodied") and then longing for their narcotic powers, the tantalizing "opiates" that she knows lie just inside their seed pods. The tiny, condensed stanzas allow each of these images to glow with nightmarish vividness.

The final one-line stanza, meanwhile, captures what the speaker longs for most: freedom from any kind of experience, even the (arguably) rather lovely sight of all those red poppies. A "colorless" world, she imagines, is one in which she won't feel the pain that dogs her anymore. By leaving the short closing line all on its own, the poem captures the speaker's sheer hopeless exhaustion in the face of her suffering.

METER

Written in [free verse](#), "Poppies in July" doesn't use a regular [meter](#). The poem instead builds its rhythms through a repeating stanza structure (all two-liners until the one-line conclusion) and through changing line length.

For instance, listen to the swing of lines 1-2:

Little poppies, little hell flames,
Do you do no harm?

The two clauses in the first line—"Little poppies" and "little hell flames"—mirror each other in their rhythms (both have a **DA-dum DA-dum** swing: "little poppies, little hell flames") and their language (the [anaphora](#) on "little"). Against that singsong similarity, the second line's intense monosyllables stand out, each word plunking into place like a pebble dropped into a pond.

RHYME SCHEME

"Poppies in July" doesn't use a [rhyme scheme](#). Instead of making music through rhyme, the poem plays with echoing sound in the form of [alliteration](#) (as in the /f/ sounds of "flame" and "flicker") or through repeating sentence structures like [anaphora](#) (as in the repeated "I" of "I cannot touch you. / I put my hand among the flames").



VOCABULARY

Fumes (Line 9) - Gases, vapors (especially potent or strong-smelling ones).

Opiates (Line 10) - A class of drugs derived from poppies. Opiates relieve pain, induce sleep, and sometimes cause hallucinations and vivid dreams. They're also highly addictive.

Nauseous capsules (Line 10) - Sickening pills.

Stilling (Line 14) - Making still; taking away movement.

Dulling (Line 14) - Muting, blunting.



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

"Poppies in July" is written in [free verse](#). That means that it



SPEAKER

Critics often read the speaker of "Poppies in July" as Plath herself. One of the most prominent Confessional poets—a group of writers known for their intensely personal verse—Plath often wrote openly about the most intimate of

subjects. She wrote this poem during a burst of intense creativity in 1962, not long after discovering that her husband, fellow poet [Ted Hughes](#), had been unfaithful to her.

Though the speaker is oblique about the source of her pain, she's clearly suffering terribly. The sight of a field of July poppies only makes her think of "hell flames" and "a mouth just bloodied"—suffering, condemnation, and violence. She longs either to be able to "bleed" or to "sleep": to make some public show of her pain, or to become unconscious. She imagines the poppies might help her with the latter problem, too: as the source of opium (among other narcotics), they might, she dreams, "dull[] and still[]" her pains, if only she could get at their potent juices.

This speaker's vision of agony, violence, and inertia in a field of bright flowers suggests that her inner world overpowers the outer. Where an earlier Romantic poet like Wordsworth might [find consolation](#) in the natural world, this speaker can find only a reflection of her own inescapable suffering.

(Note that it is also possible to read the speaker as someone other than Plath herself.)



SETTING

The poem's title grounds readers in a specific time of year—"July"—and its intense [imagery](#) suggests that the speaker is standing in a field of poppies in full bloom. But beyond that, the poem's setting isn't very specific. With its hallucinatory visions of poppies as "little bloody skirts" and "the skin of a mouth," the setting begins to resemble a nightmare more than it does the waking world.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

The American poet Sylvia Plath (1932-1963) wrote "Poppies in July" in 1962. This was a highly productive year for Plath, who experienced a surge of creative energy in the months leading up to her death by suicide in February of 1963. It was during this time that Plath wrote many of the poems that would appear alongside "Poppies in July" in *Ariel*, her 1965 posthumous collection. (Readers of this poem might be interested to take a look at "[Poppies in October](#)," a sister poem that also appeared in *Ariel*.)

With its themes of liberation, gender, death, and rebirth, *Ariel* would make Plath famous. But its legacy has gotten entangled with Plath's personal struggles, including her mental illness and the breakdown of her marriage to fellow poet [Ted Hughes](#).

Ariel helped shape what was then the emerging genre of Confessional poetry, a mode in which poets didn't shy away from using deeply personal (and often grim) material. Plath was

especially influenced by fellow American poet [Robert Lowell](#), whose collection *Life Studies* unabashedly documented his struggle with mental illness. Given that Plath was also interested in exploring her own battle with depression, it's no surprise that she considered *Life Studies* a major influence on the personal and (at times) troubling poems that would eventually make their way into *Ariel*.

Confessional poetry signaled a break from the poetic conventions that were popular in the 1950s and 1960s, largely leaving behind form and [meter](#) in favor of free verse and relatively natural, [colloquial](#) language. By adopting this tone, poets like Lowell, Plath, Anne Sexton, and W. D. Snodgrass were able to capture elements of their personal lives and present them in relatable ways on the page. It is not an understatement to say that this poetic movement paved the way for the vast majority of contemporary poetry, which deals heavily in personal discovery.

Immersed in literature since her childhood, Plath had many poetic influences. However, her longtime affinity for Shakespeare's [The Tempest](#)—and especially the character of Ariel, the imprisoned air-spirit—has the most obvious and prominent influence on this particular collection. Plath returned to *The Tempest* for inspiration many times over the course of her career; for instance, her poem "[Full Fathom Five](#)" quotes the play. Some of her other major influences were Dylan Thomas ("[Fern Hill](#)"), William Blake ("[The Garden of Love](#)"), and Robert Lowell ("[Waking in the Blue](#)").

Since her death, Plath has become one of the most beloved, respected, and influential poets of the 20th century.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

From adolescence onward, Sylvia Plath suffered from recurring bouts of suicidal depression. Mental health treatments during her era were often crude and ineffective, and some of the treatments Plath received worsened her suffering. Much of her most famous work, including her novel [The Bell Jar](#), details her struggles with mental instability and the questionable medical practices of the time. "Poppies in July" captures Plath's own desire to either transform emotional pain into physical injury or to become altogether numb.

The poem's hints of sexual violence also speak to Plath's own experience. When she wrote this poem in 1962, she was living in England and dealing with a sudden split from her husband, who had left her for another woman. Betrayed, lonely, and caring for her two children mostly on her own, Plath poured her pain into her art.



MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem (and

Plath's related poem, "Poppies in October," which appears in the same collection). (https://youtu.be/YwMTq478LTo?si=inNvmaM_swxSloMT)

- [Plath's Legacy](#) — Read a New York Times obituary of Plath that discusses her influence. (<https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2018/obituaries/overlooked-sylvia-plath.html>)
- [An Interview with Plath](#) — Listen to an interview that Plath gave in 1962, in the midst of the intensely creative period during which she wrote this poem. (<https://youtu.be/g2IMsVpRh5c?si=6M4TbfHih0gjVluw>)
- [A Brief Biography](#) — Read a short biography of Plath via the Poetry Foundation. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/sylvia-plath>)
- [The Sylvia Plath Society](#) — Visit the Sylvia Plath Society to learn more about recent critical work on Plath. (<https://www.sylviaplathsociety.org/>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER SYLVIA PLATH POEMS

- [Ariel](#)
- [Cut](#)
- [Daddy](#)
- [Edge](#)
- [Fever 103°](#)
- [Kindness](#)
- [Lady Lazarus](#)
- [Mad Girl's Love Song](#)
- [Metaphors](#)

- [Mirror](#)
- [Morning Song](#)
- [Nick and the Candlestick](#)
- [Poppies in October](#)
- [Sheep in Fog](#)
- [Sow](#)
- [The Applicant](#)
- [The Arrival of the Bee Box](#)
- [The Moon and the Yew Tree](#)
- [The Munich Mannequins](#)
- [The Night Dances](#)
- [Tulips](#)
- [Words](#)
- [You're](#)



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